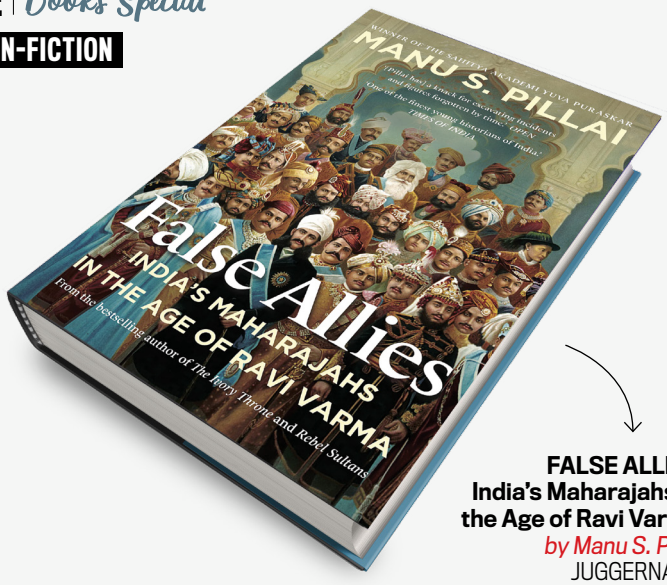


GAME OF THRONES

Manu S. Pillai throws light on the oft-ignored histories of India's princely states in *False Allies*



FALSE ALLIES
India's Maharajahs in the Age of Ravi Varma
by Manu S. Pillai
JUGGERNAUT
₹899; 528 pages

HISTORIES OF BRITISH rule in India, especially textbooks, often focus on areas which were directly administered—presidencies and provinces—ignoring the huge number of princely or 'native' states that were ruled indirectly. This represents a major absence as the over 550 states which constituted princely India, together accounted for nearly two-fifths of the territory of the Indian empire. Until quite recently, published research on princely states was woefully inadequate. However, there is now a sizeable body of scholarly studies on the subject, though these are mostly monographs or articles of a specialised nature. Manu S. Pillai has produced an accessible and well-researched book largely based on this literature to tell us the story of these political entities.

Given the sheer number, as well as the enormous diversity of states in terms of size, geography and histories of their respective relationships with the British, it is no easy task to pen an account that would be sufficiently comprehensive to give the reader a good idea about this diversity and, at the same time, rich in the kind of fascinating detail which makes for an absorbing narrative. Pillai performs this feat adroitly, selecting five princely states: Travancore, Baroda, Mysore, Pudukkottai and, somewhat unexpectedly, Mewar, which has not received much attention in the context of the modern period. What connects them is the oeuvre of Ravi Varma.

> **Given the vast number and diversity of princely states, writing a comprehensive account was no easy task, but Manu S. Pillai has done it expertly**

Ravi Varma was a product of opportunities provided by the moderately cosmopolitan milieu of Travancore, a cosmopolitanism which of course should not be exaggerated. Travancore was fortunate to have several talented administrators occupying the position of Diwan (principal bureaucrat), two of whom, Madhava Rao and Seshiah Sastri, are central to the narrative. Similarly, Mysore benefited from the presence of the great Visvesvaraya.

It is generally recognised that Baroda, Mysore and Travancore were the three most 'modern' princely states. They all had an impressive record in areas like education and industry. On the other hand, Mewar remained a backwater, notwithstanding the preeminent status of its ruling dynasty in colonial Rajasthan. The British upheld this status, influenced by James Tod's glorification of the Mewar Sisodias. They were reluctant to intervene in the affairs of the state as they routinely did in the case of most other states. Eventually pressures from below, culminating in widespread discontent in the 1920s, forced the colonial establishment to abridge the authority of the incumbent ruler Fateh Singh (r.1884-1930). The splendid illustrations which accompany the main text of *False Allies* include Ravi Varma's portrait of the handsome and regal Fateh Singh: "To those prone to romance, here was a living embodiment of all that was glorified in Rajputs" (p.321).

The book clearly demonstrates that colonialism had a stifling effect, and British meddling undermined possibilities of progress even in the most advanced states such as Baroda and Mysore. Thus, Sayaji Rao of Baroda (r.1875-1939), the most energetic among modernising princes, had to tone down his dynamism in later years to ensure that he continued to be on the throne. So much for the claim that British rule was about progress. ■

–Amar Farooqui